Consultant rota → your calendar

A step-by-step setup guide for colleagues. No coding needed.

About **20 minutes** of one-off setup puts your rota shifts into your own calendar, updated automatically every morning. Every step is clicking and copy-pasting in a web browser.

What you end up with: all-day events for each shift, colour-coded **orange** (Service), **red** (On Call) and **yellow** (CoMET), with "(Locum)" added for locum shifts. If the rota changes, your calendar follows within a day.

How it works: a small program on a free website called GitHub reads the rota each morning, finds your name and writes your shifts into a Google calendar. Outlook and iPhone users then subscribe to that calendar (Step 6).

At a glance

1	2	3	4	5	6
GitHub account	Copy the program	Rota calendar	Your 3 secrets	Switch on & test	Google / Outlook / iPhone

Before you start, have these ready

- ☐ A **computer** with a web browser (a phone works but is fiddly).
- ☐ A **Google account**. A free Gmail address is fine, even if you normally use Outlook.
- ☐ From Alex: the **key file** (a small text file ending in `.json`) and the **robot email address** (ending `.iam.gserviceaccount.com`). Keep the key file private, like a password.
- ☐ Your **first name exactly as written in the rota** (e.g. "Charlotte", not "Charlie").

> **Tip:** Open this guide on one side of the screen and your browser on the other. **Bold words** are exactly what you will see on screen to click.

1 Create a free GitHub account

GitHub stores the program and runs it on a timer for free, even when your computer is off.

1. Go to **github.com/signup**.
2. Enter any email address, choose a password and pick a username (e.g. `jane-smith`).
3. Complete the puzzle and type in the code GitHub emails you.
4. If asked to choose a plan, choose **Free**. Skip any other questions.

2 Make your own copy (a “fork”)

Your copy is yours alone. Your details never touch Alex's version.

1. While logged in, go to **github.com/dewar14/consultant-rota-scraper**.
2. Near the top right, click **Fork**.
3. On the “Create a new fork” page, change nothing and click the green **Create fork** button.
4. Check the web address now starts with `github.com/` followed by **your** username, not `dewar14`. Keep this tab open.

3 Make a rota calendar and let the robot write to it

Use a separate calendar, not your main one: the robot then only ever sees the rota, and it is the safe way to share shifts with Outlook or an iPhone.

1. Go to **calendar.google.com**, signed in to your Google account.
2. On the left, next to **Other calendars**, click **+** then **Create new calendar**.
3. Name it `Consultant rota` and click **Create calendar**.
4. On the left, under **Settings for my calendars**, click **Consultant rota**.
5. Scroll to **Share with specific people or groups** and click **Add people and groups**.
6. Paste the **robot email address** from Alex.
7. Set **Permissions** to **Make changes to events** and click **Send**. If warned it is outside your organisation, confirm.
8. Scroll down to **Integrate calendar** and copy the **Calendar ID** (a long jumble ending `@group.calendar.google.com`). Paste it into a note for Step 4.

> **Most common mistake:** the permission must say **Make changes to events**. “See all event details” will not work.

4 Add your three secrets on GitHub

"Secrets" are private settings your copy can read but nobody else can see, including Alex.

1. Back in your GitHub tab, click **Settings** (top row of tabs, far right).
2. In the left menu, click **Secrets and variables**, then **Actions**.
3. Click the green **New repository secret** button. Type the **Name** exactly as below, paste the value into **Secret**, and click **Add secret**. Repeat for all three.

Name (type exactly)	**What to paste in**
`MY_NAME`	Your first name exactly as written in the rota, e.g. `Charlotte`
`CALENDAR_ID`	The Calendar ID you copied in Step 3, ending `@group.calendar.google.com`
`GOOGLE_CREDENTIALS_JSON`	The whole contents of Alex's key file (see below)

To copy the key file: right-click it and open it with **Notepad** (Windows) or **TextEdit** (Mac). Press Ctrl+A (Cmd+A on a Mac) to select everything, copy, and paste. It should start with `{` and end with `}`.

Check: the page now lists all three names. The values show as hidden – that is normal.

5 Switch it on and run a test

GitHub keeps the timer off on new copies, so you switch it on once and test straight away.

1. In your GitHub tab, click the **Actions** tab at the top.
2. Click the green **I understand my workflows, go ahead and enable them** button.
3. In the left-hand list, click **Daily Rota Sync**.
4. On the right, click **Run workflow**, then the green **Run workflow** button that appears.
5. Wait about a minute and refresh. The spinning circle turns into a **green tick** (worked) or a **red cross** (see Troubleshooting on the last page).

Green tick? Open Google Calendar and tick **Consultant rota** on the left. Your next 16 weeks of shifts should be there. It now runs by itself every morning at about 07:00 in winter and 08:00 in summer (sometimes up to an hour late).

6 See the shifts where you look at your diary

The shifts always land in your Google “Consultant rota” calendar first. Pick the option that matches you.

Option A – Google Calendar (including Android)

Nothing more to do. Make sure **Consultant rota** is ticked. On your phone, open the Google Calendar app, go to **Settings** and switch the calendar on if it is hidden.

Option B – Outlook (or any app that takes an “iCal link”)

Outlook follows a private web link to your rota calendar. It is one-way and read-only, and Outlook may take several hours to pick up changes.

1. In Google Calendar: **Settings for my calendars → Consultant rota → Integrate calendar**.
2. Copy the **Secret address in iCal format** (ends in `.ics`). Treat it like a password.
3. **Outlook web or new Outlook:** in the calendar view click **Add calendar → Subscribe from web**, paste the link, name it `Consultant rota`, click **Import**. **Classic Outlook: File → Account Settings → Internet Calendars → New**.

> **NHS.net or work Outlook:** if the subscribe option is missing or refuses the link, IT may have blocked internet calendars. Use a personal Outlook or Option A instead.

Option C – iPhone, iPad or Mac

Simplest: add your Google account to the device. On iPhone: **Settings → Calendar** (or **Apps → Calendar**) → **Calendar Accounts → Add Account → Google**. Sign in and leave **Calendars** switched on. Updates arrive quickly.

Without adding your Google account: use the iCal link from Option B. iPhone: **Add Account → Other → Add Subscribed Calendar**. Mac: **File → New Calendar Subscription**, and set **Auto-refresh** to every hour or every day.

Menu names change between versions. Official help: support.google.com/calendar/answer/37648 (Google) and support.microsoft.com – “See your Google Calendar in Outlook”.

If something goes wrong

To see why a run failed: **Actions** tab → click the red cross → **sync** → open the step with the red cross and read the error near the bottom.

What you see	Likely cause and fix
Error mentioning **404** or **403**	Calendar not shared with the robot, or wrong Calendar ID. Redo Step 3 (permission must be **Make changes to events**) and check `CALENDAR_ID` has no extra spaces.
Error mentioning **JSON** or credentials	Key file not pasted in full. Delete `GOOGLE_CREDENTIALS_JSON` and add it again, from the first `{` to the last `}`.
Green tick but “Found 0 shifts”	`MY_NAME` does not match the rota spelling, or you have no shifts in the next 16 weeks.
Green tick but nothing in your calendar	Check you are looking at **Consultant rota** and it is ticked. Outlook and iCal can lag by hours.
Stopped updating after a couple of months	GitHub pauses timers after 60 days of no activity. **Actions** → **Daily Rota Sync** → **Run workflow** once restarts it.
A shift is missing or wrong after a re-run	Message Alex with your name, the date and a screenshot of that part of the rota.

Good to know

- **Don't edit or delete rota events by hand** – the next run puts them back. Fix the rota and the calendar follows.
- **Your own events are never touched.** The sync only manages events described as “Scraped from RITA rota”.
- **To change a detail later: Settings** → **Secrets and variables** → **Actions**, click the pencil next to the secret, update it, then run the workflow once from **Actions**.
- **Stuck?** Message Alex with the step number, a screenshot and your GitHub username.

Already set up? Update your copy

In November 2026 the rota moved to a new spreadsheet. If you made your copy before then, it is still reading the old one, so your calendar will stop following the rota until you update it. It takes about two minutes, once. **Setting up for the first time?** Skip this page – your copy already has the new address.

Update your copy

1. Go to **your** copy on GitHub – the web address starts with `github.com/` followed by your username.
2. On the **Code** tab, just above the list of files, a line says your copy is some commits **behind** `dewar14`. Click **Sync fork** next to it.
3. Click the green **Update branch** button.
4. **Actions** → **Daily Rota Sync** → **Run workflow** → green **Run workflow**, and wait for the green tick (as in Step 5).
5. Check your **Consultant rota** calendar. Your shifts should still be there, now following the new rota.

> **Only offered “Discard commits”?** Stop and message Alex rather than clicking it.

Nothing else to redo

Your secrets, your calendar and any Outlook or iPhone subscriptions stay exactly as they are. Alex has already given the robot access to the new spreadsheet.

How to tell your copy is out of date

Runs still show green ticks, but your calendar no longer matches the rota. Updating your copy as above fixes it.